

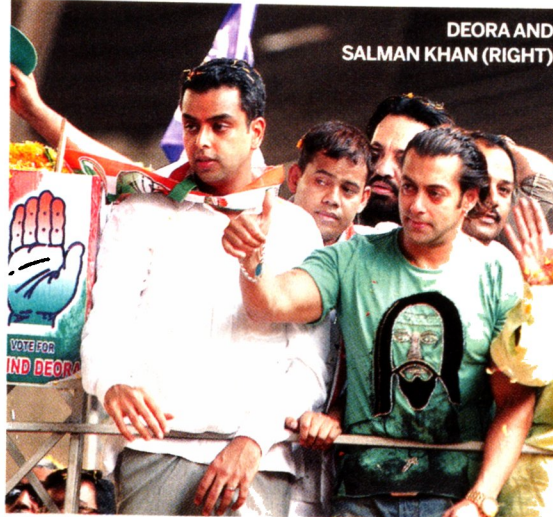
MAHESH JETHMALANI,
BJP, Mumbai North Central

An eminent lawyer and son of Ram Jethmalani, he is Sadhvi Pragya's counsel which may alienate minority votes.



BHASKAR PAUL

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**DEORA AND
 SALMAN KHAN (RIGHT)**

MILIND DEORA,
Congress, Mumbai South

Angry over a plethora of issues, people may punish him for his non-performance; also many independents and professionals are in the fray.

BHASKAR PAUL



(FROM LEFT) NAIK, GAJANAN KIRTIKAR AND GOPAL SHETTY

RAM NAIK, *BJP, Mumbai North*

The constituency was poorly served by Govinda who defeated Naik in 2004. They may make amends this time.

not enough for him to come to us only to ask for votes. He is very accessible and even responds if you write to him on his website. But that's not enough."

The Congress, with the largest number of sitting MPs in the city, could have done well by remembering how the city's electorate had punished the Shiv Sena-BJP alliance in 2004 when it lost five seats to the Congress. When it comes to punishing apathetic politicians, Mumbaikars do it best.

The spate of Mumbai's problems, relating to public infrastructure and security, is likely to impact the voting pattern this time too. Be it floods or se-

rial blasts in trains, the Mumbaikar's patience has been tested to its hilt over the last five years, during which the Congress-NCP alliance has been in power both at the Centre and in the state. This makes contests in all of the city's constituencies interesting as the saffron alliance is pitting some of its stalwarts against the roosting MPs.

Adding to the woes of politicians is the delimitation exercise, which has redrawn traditional constituencies and thereby altered their composition. Traditional vote banks have moved from existing strongholds into new constituencies and some of the

safest havens have turned unsafe for the Congress. And Mumbai South, a pocket-borough of the Congress, will have a significant portion of Parel and Worli, areas which are Sena strongholds. Kamat and Dutt, who are contesting from Mumbai North West and Mumbai North Central respectively, have to face a new mix of voters. Kamat has had to give up his comfort zones of Ghatkopar, Chembur and Trombay and will now contest from the north-Indian dominated western suburbs. And to add to his problems is Sena's Gajanan Kirtikar, who might walk away with the Maharashtrian